Kashmir's beloved religious leader Mirwaiz Qazi Nissar was murdered in his own home in Srinagar by HM terrorists in mid-1994. His funeral was followed by a general strike throughout the Vale, tens of thousands of mourners calling upon Pakistan to stay out of Kashmir. New Delhi felt confident enough by May 1995 to plan to hold an election in Kashmir, which it said would serve as a plebiscite supporting India's continued claim to Kashmir as an integral part of its union. Before that election could begin, however, the sacred Sufi shrine of Sheikh Nooruddin Noorani in Charar-i-Sharief was destroyed by flames, reviving Kashmiri opposition to India's occupation army and putting New Delhi's electoral plans on hold. A few months later, five Western climbers in Kashmir were kidnapped. One, a Norwegian, was beheaded by Lashkar killers. A young American ran away fast enough to escape, but none of the others has been heard from since. Tourism and mountain climbing in Kashmir thus came to a bone-chilling end.

By mid-1995, therefore, the Azaadi revolution in the Vale had cooled down, though a thousand or so "guerrilla" terrorists continued to be listed every year by Indian officials as killed during attacks aimed at Indian soldiers. Stalls and shops in Kashmir reopened, and handicraft production slowly started to revive throughout Srinagar and other cities. In September 1996, India sponsored statewide elections, and Farooq Abdullah was returned to power as chief minister with a two-thirds majority, despite the electoral boycott against him launched by Hurriyat Conference leaders. Charges of electoral fraud were raised by some opponents, and Farooq condemned by his enemies as a motorcycle clown because he liked to drive fast around Srinagar on his own motorbike. Others denounced him as a stooge and tool of New Delhi, but none could deny he was Kashmiri, and that his state government was, in fact, the product of ballots, not bullets.

Indian official records assert that 13,000 Kashmiri "guerrillas" were killed between 1990 and 1995, but Kashmiri resistance groups themselves have claimed that no fewer than 50,000 of them died during this half decade at the height of the Azaadi revolution. The more accurate count may be somewhere between those two. The calm that followed in the Vale was as much a product of exhaustion and exasperation on the part of many Kashmiris as of their willingness to postpone the dream of Azaadi. Few Kashmiris liked having to live in an armed camp in their very own capital, yet fewer still, probably, would prefer to see all of India's troops go south if that meant opening the